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Housing in Korea for Foreigners

Korea's rental system is unlike anywhere else in the world. Here's everything you need to know to find a home — from goshiwon to full apartment.



Types of Housing



Goshiwon (고시원)

고시원

Very small private rooms (4–8m²) in a shared building. Usually includes utilities, basic furniture, sometimes breakfast. Popular with students and new arrivals.

₩300,000–550,000/mo



One-room / Studio (원룸)

원룸

Single room with private bathroom and small kitchen. The most common housing type for single foreigners. Found everywhere in university areas.

₩400,000–900,000/mo + deposit



Officetel (오피스텔)

오피스텔

Studio or 1-bedroom units in mixed commercial/residential buildings. Better quality than typical one-rooms, often newer buildings with amenities.



Apartment (아파트)

아파트

Standard Korean apartment complexes — from studios to large family units. Best quality and amenities. Requires larger deposit (전세 or higher 보증금).

₩700,000–1,500,000/mo

₩800,000–2,500,000+/mo



Share House (쉐어하우스)

쉐어하우스

Shared house or apartment with other tenants.
Private bedroom, shared kitchen and living room.
Great for meeting people and keeping costs down.

₩400,000–700,000/mo



Hanok (한옥)

한옥

Traditional Korean wooden houses — rare but increasingly available in Bukchon, Jeonju and some renovated areas. Charming but can be cold in winter.

₩600,000–2,000,000/mo



Korea's Unique Rental System Explained



Jeonse (전세) — The Korean Lump Sum System

Jeonse is unique to Korea — instead of paying monthly rent, you give the landlord a large lump sum deposit (typically 50–80% of the property value). You live rent-free for 1–2 years, then get the full deposit back.

Example: Apartment worth ₩300M → Jeonse deposit = ₩180M–240M → You pay ₩0/month → After 2 years, you get ₩180M–240M back in full.

Why? Landlords invest the deposit and earn interest. If you have the capital, jeonse can be cheaper than renting long-term. But it requires significant upfront cash.

월세 (WOLSE) — MONTHLY RENT

- Standard monthly rent model — pay a deposit (보증금) + monthly payment
- Deposit is much smaller than jeonse (typically ₩1M–30M depending on property)
- Most practical for short/medium stays and foreigners without large capital
- Example: ₩5,000,000 deposit + ₩700,000/month for a Seoul one-room



How to Find Housing

- 1 Use the major real estate apps**
Zigbang (직방) and **Dabang (다방)** are the best apps for finding rentals. Filter by price, area, housing type. Both have maps. Naver Real Estate (네이버 부동산) is also good for apartments.
- 2 Visit a real estate agent (부동산)**
 Look for 부동산 signs — real estate agencies are on almost every block. Bring your ARC and passport. Agent fee is typically 0.3–0.9% of annual rent, paid once. Some agents near universities speak English.
- 3 View the property in person**
 Always visit before signing. Check: water pressure, heating system (온돌 floor heating), mold in corners, noise from neighbors, distance to nearest subway/bus stop.
- 4 Have the contract reviewed**
 Contracts are in Korean. Have a Korean-speaking friend, colleague or paid translator review before signing. Key terms: 계약 기간 (contract period), 보증금 (deposit), 월세 (monthly rent), 관리비 (maintenance fee).
- 5 Register your address**
 After moving in, register your address at the local community center (주민센터) within 14 days. Required for mail, banking, and many official services. Bring your ARC and rental contract.

⚠ **Watch out for:** Illegal sublets (전대차) — make sure your landlord actually owns the property. For jeonse, check the property registration (등기부등본) at any legal office or online at iros.go.kr to confirm there's no outstanding mortgage that could risk your deposit.

💰 Average Rent in Seoul by Area (2026)

AREA	CHARACTER	ONE-ROOM (월세)	JEONSE (ONE-ROOM)
Gangnam / Seocho	Upscale, business	₩900K–1.5M/mo	₩200M–350M
Mapo / Hongdae	Young, trendy	₩600K–1M/mo	₩150M–250M
Sinchon / Edae	University area	₩500K–800K/mo	₩120M–200M
Itaewon / Yongsan	Expat-friendly	₩700K–1.2M/mo	₩160M–280M
Nowon / Dobongsan	Affordable, outer	₩400K–650K/mo	₩100M–160M
Incheon	Airport city	₩350K–600K/mo	₩80M–140M

💡 **관리비 (Management fee):** Most apartments charge a monthly management fee (관리비) on top of rent — typically ₩50,000–150,000/month. It covers building maintenance, garbage, sometimes heating/water. Always ask: 관리비 포함이에요? (Is management fee included?)

Housing Korean Phrases

방 구하고 있어요.	<i>bang gu-ha-go i-sseo-yo.</i>	I'm looking for a room.
월세로 보여주세요.	<i>wol-se-ro bo-yeo-ju-se-yo.</i>	Please show me monthly rent options.
보증금이 얼마예요?	<i>bo-jeung-geum-i eol-ma-ye-yo?</i>	How much is the deposit?
관리비 포함이에요?	<i>gwal-li-bi po-ham-i-e-yo?</i>	Is the management fee included?
언제부터 입주 가능해요?	<i>eon-je-bu-teo ip-ju ga-neung-hae-yo?</i>	When is it available to move in?
계약서 영어로 있어요?	<i>gye-yak-seo yeong-eo-ro i-sseo-yo?</i>	Is the contract available in English?

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